

A giant among contenders

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Every World Cup, when the draw is announced, one of the things that stirs excitement among fans is finding out the 'group of death'. The clash of heavyweights, paired with the possibility of a weaker nation springing a surprise like Japan did last edition, sets up numerous plotlines. But this time around, the expansion to 48 teams has spread the giants apart, with Group I as good as one could hope for.

First up is France.

With head coach Didier Deschamps announcing that he will be stepping down from his post after the tournament, he could not have asked for a better group of players to have one final crack at the greatest prize.

Two words best describe France: fast and lethal. Its front three of Kylian Mbappe, Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise have scored a combined 83 goals for their clubs this season. And with first-choice striker Hugo Ekitike missing out due to injury, the goalscoring duties are expected to fall mainly on captain Mbappe, who is likely

to be deployed through the middle.

Moreover, the two-time champion has some of the game's brightest talents, like Desire Doué, Rayan Cherki and Bradley Barcola, to call upon from the bench.

And as much as one can praise its attack, France also possesses some of the best at keeping the ball out of the net. William Saliba and Dayot Upamecano, who are league winners with Arsenal and Bayern Munich this season, form the crux of an experienced backline that also has the likes of Jules Kounde and the Hernandez brothers — Theo and Lucas.

The evergreen N'Golo Kanté and his promised successor Aurelien Tchouameni in midfield cap off a dazzling side that breezed through the qualifiers with five wins, one draw and 16 goals scored.

But while France's 16 goals were spread across seven players, in the Nordic region of Europe Erling Haaland equalled the tally on his own while guiding Norway to its first Finals appearance in almost three decades. For context, the 6' 5" striker is among 15



FRANCE

FIFA Ranking: 1

Appearances: 16

Best finish: Winner (1998, 2018)

Matches: 73

Wins: 39

Draws: 14

Losses: 20

Goals For: 136

Goals Against: 85

Highest scorer in the squad
Kylian Mbappe (56 goals)



NORWAY

FIFA Ranking: 31

Appearances: 3

Best finish: Round of 16 (1938, 1998)

Matches: 8

Wins: 2

Draws: 3

Losses: 3

Goals For: 7

Goals Against: 8

Highest scorer in the squad
Erling Haaland (55 goals)

